A FREE, PLAIN-SPOKEN GUIDE



Stop Before You Pay

A Plain-Spoken Guide to Online Money Scams and What to Do If You Already Paid

Investment & crypto • Fake shops • Fake jobs
Payment apps • Marketplaces • Recovery scams

D.A. Williams

Stop Before You Pay

A Plain-Spoken Guide to Online Money Scams: Fake Investments, Shops, Jobs, Payment Apps, and What to Do If You Already Paid

D.A. Williams

Published by Red Pills of Freedom

Free to share. Please pass it on to someone who needs it.

Dedicated to Mom, Janis Fredlund

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This book is for general education. It is not legal or financial advice. Facts and figures come from government agencies and other sources listed in the Notes, as they appeared in October 2026. Scams change fast, and so do phone numbers and websites. **Always look up an organization's contact information yourself.**

The short scenes marked "Example" in this book are made up to show how a scam works. They are not stories about real people.

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INTRODUCTION

Where the Money Is Going

In 2025, people filed 3 million fraud reports with the Federal Trade Commission (FTC) and reported losing $15.9 billion. That was up from 2.6 million reports and more than $12 billion in 2024. The FTC says reported fraud losses have gone up every year for six years and have risen nearly 430% since 2020.[1]

The FBI's Internet Crime Complaint Center (IC3) counts reports a different way, but its numbers point the same direction. In 2025, it received 1,008,597 complaints, with $20.877 billion in reported losses, a 26% increase from 2024.[4]

The FTC points to research showing that only 4.8% of people who experienced mass-market consumer fraud complained to a Better Business Bureau or a government agency.[1]

What the 2025 numbers tell us

Here is what the FTC reported about 2025, in its March 2026 testimony to Congress:[1]

- **Investment scams cost the most.** People reported losing more than $7.9 billion, about half of all reported fraud losses. The average individual loss was over $10,000.
- **Imposter scams were reported most often.** More than 1 million reports, with more than $3.5 billion lost. Imposters pretend to be a business, a government agency, a relative, or someone else you trust.
- **Bank payments led to the biggest losses, followed by cryptocurrency.** Credit cards were the payment method people mentioned most often.
- **Texts were the top way scammers first made contact,** when people said how it started. But **social media led to the most money lost.**

A separate FTC report found that in 2025, nearly 30% of people who reported losing money to a scam said it started on social media, with $2.1 billion in reported losses. That is about eight times the 2020 figure.[3]

The FBI's 2025 report adds two more headlines. Investment fraud led all crime types in losses, at about $8.6 billion. And complaints involving cryptocurrency, of any kind, added up to more than $11.3 billion in losses.[4]

A note on these figures: the FTC's full 2025 Consumer Sentinel Data Book was not posted on its reports page when this book was written in October 2026, so the 2025 FTC figures here come from the FTC's own testimony to Congress and its 2026 Data Spotlight.[2,1,3] The FBI figures come from the *2025 Internet Crime Report*.

Who this book is for

Anyone who buys, sells, invests, works, or sends money online. That is nearly all of us.

You don't need to know anything about technology or investing. Each chapter explains one kind of scam in plain words, then gives you short steps. Chapters 11 through 13 cover how to check before you pay, how to pay more safely, what to do in the first hour if you already paid, and how to report. A one-page checklist is at the back.

REMEMBER: Scammers are skilled professionals. Being fooled is not a sign that you are foolish. The best protection is a simple habit: stop, check, and talk to someone before you pay.

CHAPTER 1

The Signs Every Money Scam Shares

Scams come in many costumes. Underneath, most of them work the same way. If you learn these signs, you can spot scams you have never heard of before.

Sign 1: They tell you how to pay, and it's a way that's hard to undo

The FTC says scammers "often insist" you pay by wire transfer, payment app, cash, gift card, or cryptocurrency, because "it's hard to track who the money went to" and "hard to get your money back."[5]

The FTC puts it plainly in another place: never buy anything from online sellers who insist you can only pay with gift cards, wire transfers, a payment app, or cryptocurrency.[6]

Sign 2: They promise money that is too easy

Guaranteed profits. Big returns with little risk. A job that pays well for clicking "like." A prize you didn't enter. The FTC says only scammers will guarantee that you'll make

huge profits, earn enough to quit your job, or beat the stock market.[7]

Sign 3: They rush you

"Act now." "This offer ends today." "Your account will be frozen in one hour." The FTC says high-pressure sales tactics are a red flag. So is "someone who discourages you from taking time to do some research."[7]

Sign 4: They contacted you first, out of the blue

A text from a wrong number. A friend request from a stranger. A call from your "bank." A pop-up on your screen. An unexpected job offer. The FTC says to ignore generic and unexpected texts or WhatsApp messages about jobs, because real employers will never contact you that way.[8]

Sign 5: They want secrecy

"Don't tell your bank why you are moving the money." "Keep this between us." The FBI describes scammers telling people not to inform anyone of the real reason they are moving their money.[9] The FTC says no legitimate fraud department will tell you to keep the call a secret.[10]

Sign 6: Money is supposed to flow back to them

They send you a check, then ask you to send part of it somewhere. They "accidentally" pay you too much and ask for the difference back. The FTC says that in a fake check scam, the person "always" has a good story for why you can't keep all the money.[11]

What to do when you see any of these signs

1. **Stop.** Do not pay, click, or download anything yet.
2. **Hang up or stop replying.** You can always come back to a real offer. A scam can't survive a pause.
3. **Check it yourself.** Look up the company, agency, or person on your own. Use a number from a statement, the back of your card, or the official website you type in yourself. Chapter 11 shows you how.
4. **Talk to someone you trust.** The FTC suggests talking it over with a trusted friend or family member.[10]

THE NUMBER ONE RULE: If someone you haven't met in person asks you to send money, buy gift cards, buy crypto, or move your savings, stop. Check it out with someone you trust before you do anything else.

CHAPTER 2

Investment and Crypto Scams, Including “Pig Butchering”

Investment scams caused more reported losses in 2025 than any other kind of fraud, according to both the FTC and the FBI.[1,4]

How investment scams work

The FTC says investment scams claim you’ll make a lot of money quickly or easily with little or no risk. They often involve the financial markets, cryptocurrency, real estate, or precious metals and coins.[7]

Some start with an ad, a social media post, or a “free” class. Others start with a message from a stranger. The FTC describes a common crypto version: a person contacts you on social media or a dating app, says they’ve made lots of money investing in crypto, and offers to show you how. They send you to a website or app to invest. The FTC says “the company taking your money isn’t really investing it — and the company isn’t

real.” You see fake reports showing your money growing, and you are urged to invest more.[7]

The FTC’s 2025 social media data describes scammers who ran WhatsApp groups full of “successful investors” sharing fake testimonials. People saw fake profits on real-looking platforms and were sometimes allowed to withdraw a small amount. That builds trust, so people invest more.[3]

What “pig butchering” means

“Pig butchering” is a name for a long-con crypto investment scam. The U.S. Treasury’s Financial Crimes Enforcement Network (FinCEN) explains that the name comes from fattening a hog before slaughter. Scammers use fake identities, the promise of a relationship, and elaborate stories to “fatten up” a victim’s trust before they take the money.[12]

FinCEN and the FBI both say these scams are largely run by criminal groups based in Southeast Asia that force victims of human trafficking to do the work of scamming.[12,4]

The FBI describes the pattern this way:[4]

- First contact comes by text message, social media, an ad, or a dating app.
- The conversation quickly moves to a messaging app.

- The victim is introduced to “investment groups” or “insiders” who offer tips on crypto or gold.
- The victim sends crypto to a fake investment platform or app, sees fake profits, and may be offered loans to invest more.
- When the victim tries to withdraw, they are charged “taxes” and “fees,” a final attempt to take more money before the scammers disappear.
- Victims are also targeted by recovery scams (see Chapter 10).

The numbers

- The FBI received 61,559 complaints about cryptocurrency investment fraud in 2025, with $7.228 billion in reported losses. Complaints rose 48% and losses rose 25% from 2024. People 60 and older reported the largest share of those losses: about $2.76 billion.[4]
- The FTC says investment scams caused the biggest reported losses of scams that started on social media in 2025: $1.1 billion, more than half the money reported lost on social media.[3]
- The FBI also counted about 1,600 complaints, with $160 million lost, about “investment club” scams that recruit people through social media and messaging apps.[4]

One more finding stands out. The FBI’s Operation Level Up finds victims of crypto investment fraud and warns them. In 2025, it notified 3,780 victims, and 78% of them did not know they were being scammed.[4]

IMPORTANT: If the FBI or another agency ever contacts you about a crypto scam, check that the contact is real before you share anything. The FBI warns that scammers also impersonate the IC3, and says the IC3 will never directly contact you for information or money.[13] Look up your local FBI field office yourself.

Example: The friendly wrong number

This is a made-up example to show how the scam works.

Linda gets a text: “Hi Amy, are we still on for lunch Friday?” She replies that it’s the wrong number. The sender apologizes, and they chat. Over a few weeks, the stranger becomes a daily friend. He mentions how well his crypto trading is going and offers to show her the app his “uncle” uses. Her first $500 shows a quick profit, and she withdraws $50 to test it. It works. She puts in $20,000. When she tries to withdraw her balance, the app says she must first pay a 15% “tax.” That is the moment Linda calls her daughter, who recognizes the pattern.

What to do

1. **Never mix online friendship or romance with investment advice.** The FTC says if you meet someone on a dating site or app and they want to show you how to invest in crypto, or they ask you to send crypto, "that's a scam."[14]
2. **Never let someone you met on social media direct your investment decisions.**[3]
3. **Check the person and the firm.** The FTC suggests checking whether an investment professional or company is registered, using the free search tool at Investor.gov, run by the U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission (SEC). For precious metals and commodities, check with the Commodity Futures Trading Commission (CFTC).[7]
4. **Search the name.** Search the company or person's name with words like "review," "scam," "fraud," or "complaint."[7]
5. **Treat any "withdrawal fee" or "tax" as a sign the money is already gone.** Do not pay it.

If you invested through a platform you now suspect, go to Chapter 12 right away.

CHAPTER 3

Fake Online Stores and Social Media Shop Ads

You scroll past an ad for a brand-name jacket at 70% off. You click, pay, and wait. Nothing comes. Or something comes, but it's a cheap knockoff.

How it works

The FTC says shopping scams were the most reported scam on social media in 2025. More than 40% of people who lost money to a scam on social media said it started when they ordered something they saw in an ad, from clothes and makeup to car parts and even puppies. Many ads led to unfamiliar websites. Others sent people to sites pretending to be well-known brands offering big discounts. Most people said what they paid for never arrived. When something did show up, people often said it was counterfeit or very different from the ad.[3]

The FTC warns that clicking a scammy ad can take you to a fake website built to steal your money or your personal information, like your Social Security or bank account number.[15]

The FBI received 56,478 complaints of "non-payment/non-delivery" in 2025, with about $503 million in losses. (That category includes both buyers who paid and got nothing, and sellers who shipped and never got paid.)[4]

What to do before you buy from an ad

1. **Don't assume the seller is the brand in the ad.** The FTC says to look closely to see who the seller really is, then search that company's name with words like "scam," "complaint," or "review."[15]
2. **Compare prices.** If the price is much, much lower than everywhere else, the FTC says "it's probably a scam."[15]
3. **Go to the store yourself.** If you want the deal, type the brand's real web address into your browser yourself instead of clicking the ad.
4. **Pay by credit card.** The FTC says paying by credit card gives you the best protections if something goes wrong.[15] (See Chapter 11.)
5. **Walk away if they insist on gift cards, wire transfers, payment apps, or crypto.** The FTC says only scammers will demand you pay in those ways.[15]
6. **Read the return policy.** The FTC says the site must tell you whether you can return an item for a full refund.[6] Who pays return shipping? How many days do you have?

7. **Keep records.** Save the website address, the order confirmation, the ad, and every message.[6]

A note on “https” and the padlock

The FTC says “https” means a site is encrypted, but “it doesn’t mean it’s a legitimate site. Scammers know how to encrypt sites, too.”[6] A padlock does not mean a store is honest.

If your order never came

- **Contact the seller first,** in writing, and keep a copy.
- **If you paid by credit card,** dispute the charge. The FTC says to call right away, then send a letter that reaches your card company within 60 days of the date it mailed the first bill showing the error.[6]
- **If you paid another way,** see Chapter 12.
- **Report it** to the FTC at ReportFraud.ftc.gov and to the platform where you saw the ad.[6]

CHAPTER 4

Fake Jobs, Task Scams, Fake Checks, and Money Mules

When money is tight, a job offer feels like good news. Scammers know that.

The FTC says scammers advertise jobs the same way honest employers do: online, in ads, on job sites, and on social media. “They promise you a job, but what they want is your money and your personal information.”[16]

The FBI received 24,688 complaints about employment fraud in 2025, with about $363 million in losses.[4] And the FTC says one in three people who reported losing money to a job or business opportunity scam in 2025 said it started on social media.[3]

Task scams: “paying to get paid”

The FTC calls these “gamified” job scams. You are offered online work, often by an unexpected text or WhatsApp message. Your “job” is to do simple, repetitive tasks in an app, like liking videos or rating product pictures. The app shows commissions piling up. You might even get small payouts at first.[8]

Then, the FTC says, you're told you must deposit money to finish your next set of tasks or to get your "earnings" out. But "no matter what the system says you've earned, you didn't. That money isn't real. And if you deposit money, you won't get it back."[8]

The FTC estimated that about 20,000 people reported task scams in just the first half of 2024, compared with about 5,000 in all of 2023. It said crypto is "the currency of choice" for these scams.[8]

REMEMBER: "Never pay anyone to get paid." That's the FTC's advice, word for word.[8]

Fake checks

Many job scams, and many prize and marketplace scams, use fake checks. The FTC explains how it works: someone you don't know asks you to deposit a check, often for more than they owe you, then send some of the money back or on to someone else.[11]

The trap is timing. The FTC says banks must make deposited money available quickly, so the money shows up in your account. But it can take weeks for the bank to discover that the check is fake. By then, the scammer has the money you sent, and "you're stuck paying the money back to the bank."[11]

The FTC lists examples: fake mystery-shopper jobs, fake personal-assistant jobs that ask you to buy gift cards, car-

wrap advertising offers, prize "winnings," and buyers who "accidentally" overpay.[11]

Reshipping and money mules

Some fake jobs turn you into part of the crime without your knowing it.

- **Reshipping.** The FTC says a reshipping "job" asks you to receive packages at home, repackage them, and send them on, sometimes overseas. The goods are often bought with stolen credit cards. "Reshipping goods is never a real job."[16]
- **Money mules.** The U.S. Department of Justice says money mules are people who, at someone else's direction, receive and move money taken from fraud victims. Some know what they are doing. Others don't. People become money mules through online job ads, social media posts, "prizes," and online relationships.[17]

The Justice Department says knowingly moving money for illegal activity can lead to criminal charges. It says to closely question any job that involves opening bank accounts, receiving money or packages, or little more than sending and receiving money or gift cards.[17]

What to do

1. **Never pay for the promise of a job.** The FTC says honest employers, including the federal government, will never ask you to pay to get a job.[16]
2. **Never deposit a check from a new "employer" and send part of it anywhere.** The FTC says no honest employer will do that.[16]
3. **Ignore unexpected job texts and WhatsApp messages.**[8]
4. **Search the company name** with "scam," "review," or "complaint," and talk the offer over with someone you trust.[16]
5. **Look for work at trusted sources,** like USAJobs.gov for federal jobs and CareerOneStop from the U.S. Department of Labor.[16]
6. **If you think you've been used as a money mule:** the Justice Department says to stop communicating with the person, don't send them any money you still hold, tell your bank, and report it to law enforcement.[17]

CHAPTER 5

Payment App Scams and Overpayment Tricks

Zelle, Venmo, Cash App, and PayPal make it easy to pay a friend back for dinner. They also make it easy to pay a scammer.

Why scammers like payment apps

The FTC says it plainly: “sending money through a payment app is like sending cash — it’s very hard to get it back.”[18]

Zelle says the same about its own service. Once you authorize a payment to someone already enrolled in Zelle, “you can’t cancel it,” because the money typically moves into the other person’s bank account within minutes. Zelle says to “only send money to people you personally know and trust.” It also says Zelle “does not offer a protection program” for payments you authorized, such as when an item never arrives or isn’t as described.[19]

Common payment app tricks

- **The fake emergency.** The FTC says scammers pretend to be a loved one in trouble who needs money right away.[18]
- **The fake prize.** You "won," but you need to pay a fee to collect it.[18]
- **The fake bank.** The FTC describes scammers who pose as your bank, say there's a problem with your account, and walk you through sending money with Zelle to a "new account in your name." That account belongs to the scammer.[18]
- **The fake payment.** When you're selling something, the FTC says a fake buyer may send a fake payment notification and hope you ship the item before you notice.[20]
- **The "accidental" payment.** The FTC says a fake buyer may claim they paid you twice by mistake and ask you to refund one payment.[20]
- **The hacked friend.** The FTC says if you get an unexpected money request from someone you do know, talk to them to make sure it's really them, not a hacker who got into their account.[21]

What to do

1. **Use payment apps only with people you know and trust.** For buying from strangers, use a credit card or

a payment method with buyer protection (see Chapter 11).[19]

2. **Double-check the recipient before you hit send.** The FTC recommends this every time.[21]
3. **Protect your account** with multi-factor authentication or a PIN, and never give your account login to anyone who contacts you.[21]
4. **Know your bank's rule.** The FTC says your bank will never contact you to tell you to transfer money or to ask for personal information or passcodes.[18]
5. **Never refund an "overpayment" to a stranger.** Check your actual balance in the app or bank, not a screenshot or an email, and talk to the app company if something seems off.
6. **If you paid a scammer,** report it to the payment app right away and ask it to reverse the payment. For Zelle, report it to your bank or credit union. (See Chapter 12.)[22]

Official contacts for Cash App, Venmo, PayPal, and the big wire transfer companies are listed in the Resources section at the back of this book.

IMPORTANT: Scammers buy search ads with fake "customer service" numbers. The FTC warns not to rely on top search results for a company's phone number.[10] Start from the app itself or the company's official website.

CHAPTER 6

Buying and Selling on Online Marketplaces

Facebook Marketplace, Craigslist, and similar sites are full of honest neighbors. The FTC says they also attract "a lot of buyers — and scammers."[20]

If you're selling

The FTC describes three common tricks used on sellers:[20]

1. **Fake payments and bogus refund requests.** The "buyer" insists on a payment app, sends a fake payment notice, or says they paid twice and wants one payment refunded.
2. **Fake check overpayment.** The "buyer" sends a check for more than your price and asks you to send back the difference. The check is fake, but it can show up in your balance first.
3. **Fake verification codes.** The "buyer" says they want to make sure you're a real person and asks for a code they sent you by text. It is a Google Voice code. If you share it, the FTC says, the scammer can create a

Google Voice number linked to your real phone number and use it to cheat other people.

What the FTC recommends for sellers:[20]

- Many sites recommend selling to a local buyer you meet in person and accepting only cash.
- If you're not selling locally, see what seller protections the site offers.
- Don't accept a mobile payment from someone you don't know.
- Never deposit a check for more than the selling price.
- Don't share a verification code, from Google Voice or anywhere else, with someone you don't know.

If you're buying

The FTC says some marketplaces leave payments, returns, and refunds entirely up to buyers and sellers. Others have a process to help if you never get the item or it isn't what was advertised.[23] Before you buy, find out which kind you're on.

What the FTC recommends for buyers:[23]

- **Check the seller.** Look at ratings and recent comments, but don't rely on star ratings alone. Some reviews are fake.

- **Look at the photos.** If you only see stock photos, you can't check the item's condition or be sure the seller really has it.
- **Be wary of very low prices.** An expensive item listed very cheap might be fake.
- **Use a safer payment method,** like a credit card or a secure online payment system that protects buyers.
- **Don't pay with wire transfers, gift cards, cash reload cards, or crypto.**
- **Don't pay outside the marketplace's own payment system.** If you do, the FTC says, you lose any protection the site offers.
- **Keep track of deadlines** for returns and refund claims, and keep copies of all messages.

Example: The couch and the "verification code"

This is a made-up example to show how the scam works.

Marcus lists a couch for $150. A buyer messages right away: "Is it still available? I've seen a lot of fake listings, so I'm going to text you a code to make sure you're real." A six-digit code arrives by text. Marcus remembers what he read about Google Voice codes. He doesn't send it, and he tells the buyer he only sells for cash, in person, in the parking lot of his local police station. The buyer disappears. A real buyer comes the next day.

Safety when you meet in person

Common sense goes a long way: meet in a busy public place in daylight, bring someone with you, and tell someone where you're going. For sellers, the FTC notes that many sites recommend meeting local buyers in person and taking only cash.[20]

CHAPTER 7

The “Fraud Department” Call That Moves Your Money “to Safety”

The FBI’s 2025 report ranks tech support scams third in reported losses, after investment fraud and business email compromise.[4] Many of them are aimed at your life savings.

How it works

The FBI calls one common version the “Phantom Hacker” scam. It comes in three phases:[9]

1. **The fake tech support.** A pop-up, text, call, or email says your computer has a problem and tells you to call a number. The “technician” asks you to download software that lets them control your computer. They pretend to find a hacker, then ask you to open your financial accounts to “check for unauthorized charges.” This shows them which account has the most money.
2. **The fake bank.** Someone posing as your bank’s or brokerage’s fraud department calls. They say a foreign

hacker has gotten into your accounts and you must move your money to a “safe” account, sometimes said to be at the Federal Reserve or another government agency. They tell you to send it by wire, cash, or crypto, often over days or months, and not to tell anyone the real reason.

3. **The fake government agent.** Someone posing as a government employee may call, or send official-looking letters, to keep you moving money.

Other versions start with a call about fraud on your card, a hacked account, a tax debt, or benefits ending today.[10] Some end with a courier coming to your door to pick up cash or gold. The FBI counted about 725 complaints about “gold courier” scams in 2025, with $311.8 million in losses.[4]

The numbers

In 2025, the FBI received 47,794 complaints about tech and customer support scams, with about $2.13 billion in losses, and 32,424 complaints about government impersonation, with about $798 million in losses.[4] It also counted about 4,700 complaints, with $359.7 million in losses, about “account takeover” scams in which criminals pose as a bank’s support staff.[4]

The rule that stops this scam cold

The FTC’s advice is short and absolute:[24]

- **“Never move or transfer your money to ‘protect it.’”** Your money is fine where it is. “Someone who says you have to move your money to protect it is a scammer. Period.”
- **Never share a verification code.** The FTC says no caller, “especially someone from your bank’s fraud department,” will ever ask for it.

THE MOST IMPORTANT THING TO KNOW: Anyone who tells you to move your money to keep it safe is a scammer.[24] The FTC says real businesses and government agencies will never tell you to use a Bitcoin ATM to protect your money,[25] and the FTC itself will never tell you to withdraw cash or buy gold and give it to someone.[22]

What to do if you get one of these calls

The FTC’s January 2026 advice:[10]

1. **Get the basic details, then hang up.** “Yes, hang up.”
2. **Contact the company yourself.** Use the official app or website, or the phone number on a recent statement or the back of your card. Don’t trust top search results; scammers buy search ads with fake numbers.

3. **Talk to a trusted friend or family member.** No legitimate fraud department will tell you to keep the call a secret.
4. **Never** share your personal or account information, give anyone remote access to your phone or computer, or share a verification code.

The FBI adds: don’t click unexpected pop-ups or links, don’t call a number from a pop-up, text, or email, and don’t download software because someone who contacted you asked you to.[9]

If you already moved money, go to Chapter 12 now. Call your bank’s real fraud number, using the number on your card or statement.

CHAPTER 8

Giveaway, Prize, and Lottery Scams

“Congratulations! You’ve won!” Few words are more exciting. Scammers count on that.

How it works

The FTC says you get a call, email, text, letter, or social media message saying you won a sweepstakes, lottery, or prize. Then comes the catch: you have to pay money, or give your account information, to get it. “If you pay, you’ll lose your money and find out there is no prize.”[5]

The FBI received 5,623 complaints about lottery, sweepstakes, and inheritance fraud in 2025, with about $194 million in losses.[4]

Online giveaway scams are a close cousin. The FTC warns about scammers who pretend to be a celebrity who can “multiply” any crypto you send, and about promises of free cash or crypto, which it says “are always fake.”[14]

The FTC's three signs of a prize scam[5]

1. **You have to pay to get your prize.** Real prizes are free. A fee for "taxes," "shipping and handling," "processing," or "customs" means it's a scam.
2. **You have to pay to improve your odds.** Real sweepstakes are free and by chance. The FTC says it's illegal to ask you to pay to increase your odds of winning.
3. **You have to give financial or personal information.** There's no reason to give your bank account, credit card number, or Social Security number to claim a prize.

Other tricks to watch for[5]

- **Fake government names,** like a made-up "National Sweepstakes Bureau," or a real agency's name, like the FTC. The government won't call you demanding money to collect a prize.
- **Real company names.** Scammers pose as companies that run real sweepstakes. Look up the real company's contact information yourself.
- **Foreign lotteries.** The FTC says it's illegal for U.S. citizens to play a foreign lottery, and messages about one are "almost certainly from a scammer."
- **A check in the mail.** If you deposit a prize check and send money back for "fees," it's the fake check scam from Chapter 4.

- **“Act now.”** Pressure to claim a prize fast is a warning sign.

What to do

1. **Never pay to claim a prize.** Not a fee, not taxes, not shipping.
2. **Don’t click links** in a “you won” text, email, or social media message. The FTC says they might download malware onto your device.[5]
3. **Check the mailing.** If a notice came by bulk-rate mail, the FTC says many other people got the same one.[5]
4. **Report it** to the FTC at ReportFraud.ftc.gov, and to the U.S. Postal Inspection Service if it came by mail.[5]

CHAPTER 9

Crypto ATMs

You may have seen them at gas stations, convenience stores, and grocery stores: machines that look a bit like ATMs but turn your cash into cryptocurrency. The FTC calls them Bitcoin ATMs, or BTMs, and says they let you buy or send crypto. It also says scammers now use them to steal people's money.[25]

How the scam works

The FTC describes it like this.[26] It starts with a call, a message, or a fake security warning on your computer about "suspicious activity" or "unauthorized charges." The story quickly gets scarier: your money is at risk, or you're linked to money laundering or drug smuggling. A fake government agent may come on the line.

Then the scammer says that putting cash into one of these machines will protect your money or fix the problem. Scammers have even called them "safety lockers." They send you to your bank to take out cash, then to a specific machine. They text you a QR code to scan. Once you scan it and feed in the cash, the money goes straight into the scammer's crypto wallet.

The numbers

- **FTC:** Fraud losses at Bitcoin ATMs rose nearly tenfold from 2020 to 2023 and topped $65 million in just the first half of 2024. The median loss reported was $10,000. People 60 and over were more than three times as likely as younger adults to report a loss at one of these machines, and they lost about 71% of the money ($46 million).[26]
- **FBI:** In 2025, the IC3 received 13,460 complaints involving crypto ATMs or kiosks, with $389 million in losses. That was a 23% increase in complaints and a 58% increase in losses over 2024. People 60 and older filed 6,188 of those complaints and reported about $257 million in losses.[4]

What to do

The FTC's advice:[26,25]

1. **Don't believe anyone who says you need to use a Bitcoin ATM, buy gift cards, or move money to protect it or fix a problem.** "Real businesses and government agencies will never do that."
2. **Never withdraw cash in response to an unexpected call or message.** "Only scammers will tell you to do that."
3. **Slow down and talk with someone you trust** before you do anything else.

4. **Check the story yourself,** using a phone number, website, or app you know is real. Never use the contact information from the call or message.
5. **Report it** at ReportFraud.ftc.gov.

REMEMBER: If someone is on the phone telling you what to do while you stand at a crypto ATM, stop and hang up. The FTC warns that some scammers stay on the phone and give step-by-step instructions at the machine.[14]

If you already put money in a crypto ATM

Act fast. The FTC says to contact the ATM operator (or the crypto exchange) immediately, tell them it was a fraudulent transaction, and ask them to reverse it and refund your money. Then report it to the FTC.[22] Report it to the FBI at ic3.gov too, with the wallet address, the transaction details, and your receipt.[27] The FTC notes that crypto payments don't have the same legal protections as credit and debit cards, but some states have passed laws that might help.[22] Keep the paper receipt from the machine.

CHAPTER 10

Recovery Scams

This is the cruelest scam of all, because it targets people who have already been scammed.

How it works

The FTC says recovery scammers contact you and claim they can get back the money you lost, but you need to pay them first. “If you do, you’ll lose more money.”[28]

The FTC explains that scammers buy and sell lists of people who’ve already lost money to scams. They may say they’re with a government agency, a consumer group, or a law firm. They may ask for a “retainer fee,” “processing fee,” or “tax,” or for your bank account number so they can supposedly deposit a refund.[28]

The FBI warns about fake law firms that contact crypto scam victims through social media and messaging apps, claim to be working with the FBI, the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau (CFPB), or another agency, and ask for upfront fees or banking information.[27] Scammers also impersonate the IC3 itself.[13]

In 2025, the FBI received 10,516 complaints about recovery scams, with about $1.4 billion in reported losses. (The FBI notes that this may include money lost in the earlier scams that led people to the recovery contact.)[4]

The rules that protect you

- **"Law enforcement does not charge victims a fee for investigating crimes."** That's from the FBI. If someone claims to be with the FBI, the FBI says to contact your local field office to confirm.[27]
- **Government agencies and legitimate organizations will never ask for money to help you get a refund,** and will never guarantee you'll get your money back, according to the FTC.[28]
- **Never pay upfront for help getting a refund,** and never give your bank, card, or Social Security number to get one.[28]
- **Be wary of ads for crypto recovery services.** The FBI says to watch for vague language, a minimal online presence, and promises that they can recover funds.[27]

What to do

1. **Don't reply** to anyone who contacts you offering to recover lost money.

2. **Report your original loss yourself,** directly to your bank, the FTC, and ic3.gov. That's free. You never need a "recovery company" to file a report for you.
3. **Look up any agency's number yourself** and call to confirm, as the FTC advises. Don't call a number they gave you.[28]
4. **Report the recovery scammer** to the FTC and your state attorney general.[28]

IMPORTANT: Anyone who asks for an upfront fee to get your money back is a scammer.[28]

CHAPTER 11

Check Before You Pay, and Pay the Safer Way

You don't need to know every scam. You need a few habits.

A five-minute check before you pay anyone new

1. **Who contacted whom?** If they reached out to you first, be extra careful.
2. **Look them up yourself.** Search the company or person's name with "scam," "complaint," or "review."[7] For investments, check registration at Investor.gov.[7]
3. **Find the real contact information on your own.** Use the number on your card or statement, or the official app or website you type in yourself. Don't trust top search results.[10]
4. **Listen for the warning signs from Chapter 1:** a specific hard-to-undo payment method, a guarantee, a rush, secrecy, or money that must be sent back.
5. **Talk to someone you trust.**[16]

How safe is each way to pay?

Here is how the FTC describes the main payment methods. When something goes wrong, they are not equal.

How you pay	What the FTC says
Credit card	"Paying by credit card best protects you and your money in case of a scam." You can dispute charges for things you never got or that were wrong.[6]
Debit card	Federal law protects you from unauthorized use. If you were tricked into paying, report it to your bank right away and ask for a refund.[22]
Payment app (Venmo, Cash App, PayPal, Zelle)	"Like sending cash — it's very hard to get it back." Use with people you know.[18]
Wire transfer	Report it immediately and ask for a reversal. Reversal is unlikely, but ask.[11]
Gift card	"Gift cards are for gifts, not payments. Anyone who demands payment by gift card is always a scammer."[11]
Cryptocurrency	Payments "typically are not reversible" and "do not come with legal protections."[14]
Cash	If you mailed it, call the U.S. Postal Inspection Service right away. For a fee, it can intercept a domestic package that hasn't been delivered.[22]

The safer-payment rules

1. **When you buy from a stranger or an unfamiliar store, use a credit card.**[6]
2. **Keep payment apps for friends and family.**[19]
3. **On a marketplace, pay inside the site's own payment system,** never outside it.[23]
4. **Never pay a stranger with gift cards, wire transfers, crypto, or cash.** The FTC says only scammers will insist that you pay only in ways like these.[28]
5. **Never use money from a check to send gift cards, money orders, crypto, or wire transfers** to someone who asks.[11]

Set up your accounts before trouble starts

- **Turn on account alerts** with your bank and card companies so you see every charge.
- **Turn on multi-factor authentication** for your bank, email, and payment apps.[21]
- **Consider adding a trusted contact person** to any brokerage account. The SEC, FINRA, and state securities regulators explain that this is someone your brokerage firm may contact in limited circumstances, such as when it can't reach you or believes your account may be exposed to financial exploitation. Naming a trusted contact does not give that person

any authority to make transactions or decisions on your account.[29]

CHAPTER 12

The First Hour If You Already Paid

If you've paid a scammer, take a breath. Then move quickly. The FBI says that when you discover a fraudulent transfer, "time is of the essence."[4]

The FBI's Recovery Asset Team works with banks to try to freeze money sent to scammers. In 2025, it acted on 3,900 incidents and helped freeze about $679 million, a 58% success rate by the FBI's measure.[4] That is not a promise. But it can only work if you act fast and report with full details.

Step 1: Stop the bleeding (minutes 1–10)

- **Stop all contact with the scammer.** Don't send "one last payment" to unlock your money.
- **If they had remote access to your computer,** disconnect it from the internet.
- **Don't delete anything.** Messages, receipts, wallet addresses, and phone numbers are evidence.

Step 2: Call the company you paid through (minutes 10–30)

The FTC's advice is the same for nearly every payment method: report it immediately and ask them to reverse the payment and refund your money.[22]

- **Bank transfer or Zelle:** call your bank or credit union. Use the number on your card or statement.[22] For a wire or bank transfer, the FBI says to ask for "a recall of the funds."[4]
- **Credit or debit card:** call the number on the back of your card.[22]
- **Payment app:** report it inside the app. Official contacts are in the Resources section.[22]
- **Wire transfer company:** call the company and tell them a scammer tricked you. The FTC lists MoneyGram at 1-800-666-3947 and Western Union at 1-800-325-6000.[11]
- **Gift card:** call the card company using the number on the back of the card. Keep the card and receipt.[22]
- **Crypto or crypto ATM:** contact the exchange or ATM operator.[22]
- **Cash by U.S. mail:** call the U.S. Postal Inspection Service at 1-877-876-2455. The FTC says that, for a fee, it can intercept a domestic package that hasn't been delivered yet.[22]

- **Cash by FedEx or UPS:** contact the delivery company as soon as possible.[22]

Say the word “fraud” clearly. Write down the date, time, the name of the person you spoke with, and any claim or case number.

Step 3: File with the FBI (within the hour if you can)

Go to **ic3.gov**. The FBI says to file “regardless of the amount lost” and to include full transaction details.[4] Have ready:[27]

- How the person first contacted you, and the names, numbers, emails, and usernames they used.
- The date, type, and amount of each payment.
- Account numbers, the receiving bank’s name, and any crypto wallet addresses.

Step 4: Protect what’s left (the rest of the day)

- **Change passwords,** starting with your email, and turn on two-factor authentication.[22]
- **If you gave out your Social Security number,** go to IdentityTheft.gov for a recovery plan.[22]
- **If someone had access to your computer,** update your security software, run a scan, and change your passwords.[22]

- **Tell someone you trust.**

Step 5: Watch out for the second wave

After a loss, you may be targeted by a recovery scam (Chapter 10). Anyone who asks for a fee to get your money back is a scammer.[28]

For a full, step-by-step recovery plan, see the companion guide After a Scam *by the same author.*

CHAPTER 13

How to Report It

The FTC says it uses reports to build cases against scammers, spot trends, and educate the public.[22] And the FBI's freezes depend on fast reports.[4]

You can, and often should, report to more than one place.

Where to report

1. **Your bank, card company, or payment app.** Always first, because they are the ones who can try to stop or reverse the payment.[22]
2. **The FTC:** ReportFraud.ftc.gov or 1-877-FTC-HELP (1-877-382-4357).[30]
3. **The FBI's Internet Crime Complaint Center:** ic3.gov. Especially for crypto, wire, and bank transfer losses.[4]
4. **The platform where it started.** Report the seller, profile, ad, or listing to the marketplace, social media site, or app. The FTC says to contact the marketplace to report a seller if you can't resolve a problem.[23]
5. **The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau (CFPB):** consumerfinance.gov/complaint or 855-411-2372, if you have a problem with a bank, credit card, money

transfer service, prepaid card, or virtual currency company. The CFPB sends complaints to the company and says most companies respond within 15 days.[31]

6. **Your state attorney general.** Find yours through the National Association of Attorneys General at naag.org.[31]
7. **For investment scams:** the SEC at sec.gov/tcr, and the CFTC at cftc.gov/complaint for precious metals, commodities, or crypto.[7,14]
8. **For scams that came by mail:** the U.S. Postal Inspection Service.[5]
9. **Your local police,** especially if you need a police report for your bank.[31]

If you are 60 or older, the U.S. Department of Justice's National Elder Fraud Hotline can help: 1-833-FRAUD-11 (1-833-372-8311).[32]

Tips for a strong report

Include every detail: names, usernames, phone numbers, websites, wallet addresses, and how you paid.[27] Keep a copy of every report and its confirmation number. And remember: "Law enforcement does not charge victims a fee for investigating crimes."[27]

REMEMBER: Reporting is nothing to be embarrassed about. As the FTC puts it, your complaint "can help protect other people."[30]

APPENDIX

The One-Page Stop Before You Pay Checklist

Print this page. Free to copy and share.

THE NUMBER ONE RULE: If someone you haven't met in person wants you to send money, buy gift cards or crypto, or move your savings, stop and check with someone you trust.

Before you pay anyone new

- ☐ Did *they* contact *me* first? Be extra careful.
- ☐ Searched the name with "scam," "complaint," or "review."
- ☐ Looked up the real phone number or website myself.
- ☐ No pressure, no secrecy, no guarantee of profit.
- ☐ Not being asked to pay by gift card, wire, crypto, or cash.
- ☐ Not depositing a check and sending part of it back.
- ☐ Talked it over with someone I trust.

Never, ever: Move money to "protect it" · Share a verification code · Pay to get a prize, a job, or a refund · Use a crypto ATM because someone on the phone told me to

Pay the safer way: Credit card for strangers and new stores · Payment apps only with people I know · Pay inside the marketplace

If I already paid: the first hour

- ☐ Stop contact. Save all messages and receipts.
- ☐ Call my bank, card company, app, or ATM operator. Say "fraud." Ask for a reversal.
- ☐ File at **ic3.gov** with full transaction details.
- ☐ Report at **ReportFraud.ftc.gov**.
- ☐ Change passwords. Turn on two-factor login.

Help: FTC **1-877-382-4357** · CFPB **855-411-2372** · Elder Fraud Hotline **1-833-372-8311** · USPIS **1-877-876-2455**

From Stop Before You Pay *by D.A. Williams. Sources are in the book's Notes. Not legal advice.*

RESOURCES

Where to Get Help

All of these were checked in October 2026. Phone numbers and websites can change. Look up any organization's official website yourself. Never use a "help" number that someone contacts you with.

This book is not legal or financial advice. For legal help, contact a lawyer or your local legal aid office.

To report

- **FTC:** ReportFraud.ftc.gov or 1-877-FTC-HELP (1-877-382-4357).[30]
- **FBI Internet Crime Complaint Center:** ic3.gov.[4]
- **Consumer Financial Protection Bureau:** consumerfinance.gov/complaint or 855-411-2372.[31]
- **SEC (securities and investment fraud):** sec.gov/tcr.[7]
- **CFTC (commodities, precious metals, crypto):** cftc.gov/complaint.[14]
- **Your state attorney general:** naag.org.[31]
- **U.S. Postal Inspection Service:** 1-877-876-2455.[22]
- **Identity theft:** IdentityTheft.gov.[22]

To check before you invest or hire

- **Investor.gov:** the SEC's free search tool for investment professionals.[7]
- **USAJobs.gov** for federal jobs, and **CareerOneStop** from the U.S. Department of Labor.[16]

Payment app and money transfer contacts

- **Cash App:** cash.app/help or 1-800-969-1940.[21]
- **Venmo:** 1-855-812-4430.[21]
- **PayPal:** 1-888-221-1161.[21]
- **Zelle:** your bank or credit union.[22]
- **MoneyGram:** 1-800-666-3947. **Western Union:** 1-800-325-6000.[11]

Free support

- **AARP Fraud Watch Network Helpline:** 877-908-3360, Monday–Friday, 8 a.m.–8 p.m. Eastern. Free guidance and support.[33]
- **National Elder Fraud Hotline (age 60+):** 1-833-FRAUD-11 (1-833-372-8311).[32]
- **988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline:** call or text 988.[34]
- **Emergency:** 911.

Learn more

- **FTC scam advice:** ftc.gov/scams.[8]

- **Companion guides by D.A. Williams:** *Protect Your Parents*, *After a Scam*, *Is That Really Their Voice?*, *Apps That Actually Help*, *When Banks Cheat You*, *Naked Short Selling*, *Disability Benefits Made Simple*, and *Don't Get Doxxed*, free wherever you found this book.

Notes

Web addresses were checked in October 2026. Figures are the most recent annual figures published by each agency at that time. FTC figures come from reports to its Consumer Sentinel Network; FBI figures come from complaints to its Internet Crime Complaint Center. Both agencies note that most fraud is never reported, so the true totals are higher. Quoted advice is from the agency named.

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